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Gender Justice in Mangrove Restoration across the *Sundarbans*: A Scoping Review and Comparative Policy Analysis

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1. Research Problem

The Sundarbans is a transboundary mangrove ecosystem where coastal communities depend on forest and coastal resources while facing environmental and livelihood pressures. Mangrove restoration and regeneration are increasingly connected with climate adaptation and community-based environmental governance. These interventions, however, are not solely ecological processes: they also shape who participates in environmental institutions, whose knowledge is recognized, who gains access to resources and livelihood opportunities, and how conservation responsibilities are distributed.

12 Evidence from the Bangladesh *Sundarbans* shows that women participate in forest co-management and that their participation can contribute to livelihood opportunities, household wellbeing and conservation practices. At the same time, women remain less represented in co-management institutions and men continue to dominate representation and decision-making [1]. More recent research indicates that their participation is influenced by family expectations, religious norms and wider social expectations, demonstrating that formal participation opportunities do not necessarily remove constraints on women's agency [2].

Research on social equity further shows that participation alone is insufficient for assessing environmental justice. In the Bangladesh *Sundarban*, procedural and distributional dimensions of equity have not been experienced equally; procedural and distributional equity were reported as weaker than recognitional equity [3]. Studies evaluating co-management has also identified continuing institutional and governance limitations from local forest users' perspectives [4].

The central research problem is whether restoration institutions provide meaningful opportunities for recognition, participation, decision-making, resource access, benefit distribution and accountability.

2. Existing Literature and Research Gap

Existing literature provides important but fragmented evidence. Studies of women's participation have examined their roles in forest co-management, livelihood activities and conservation [1], [2]. Research on social equity has introduced recognitional, procedural and distributional dimensions into analysis of *Sundarbans* governance [3]. Other work has examined the effectiveness and limitations of co-management arrangements from local users' perspectives [4]. Studies on community-led mangrove regeneration in the Indian *Sundarbans* additionally emphasizes the importance of community agency and place-based knowledge [5], while recent work has raised concerns about the treatment of local knowledge within mangrove restoration initiatives [6].

However, these strands of evidence have largely been examined separately. Less clearly understood is how the gender-justice concerns documented in empirical research correspond to the institutional mechanisms contained in contemporary mangrove-restoration policies and programmes across the Bangladesh and Indian Sundarbans. This study will address that gap through an evidence-to-policy analysis. It will first synthesize empirical evidence on gendered

inequalities in *Sundarbans* environmental governance and then examine whether contemporary restoration-related policies and programmes respond through identifiable mechanisms for participation, decision-making, resource access, benefit sharing and accountability.

3. Research Question

Central Research Question

How and to what extent do contemporary mangrove-restoration policies and programmes across the Bangladesh Sundarbans address gender-justice concerns identified in empirical research?

Here, "extent" will be assessed qualitatively across defined dimensions of gender justice rather than treated as a numerical measure.

Objectives

1. To synthesize gender-justice concerns documented in empirical research on environmental governance in the Sundarbans.
2. To examine how contemporary mangrove-restoration policies and programmes address women's participation, decision-making, resource access and benefit distribution.
3. To identify where policy commitments are translated into concrete institutional mechanisms, where responses remain partial, and where relevant mechanisms are not documented, and to develop evidence-based recommendations for more gender-responsive restoration governance.

4. Theoretical Framework

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The study will primarily draw on Feminist Political Ecology (FPE), which examines how gender and wider power relations shape access to environmental resources, knowledge, labour and decision-making [7]. FPE is appropriate because mangrove restoration may redistribute both environmental benefits and responsibilities rather than simply producing ecological outcomes.

Intersectionality will complement FPE by preventing "women" from being treated as a homogeneous category. Gender may intersect with livelihood, economic position, age, household status, social identity and dependence on forest resources [8]. Where the empirical literature provides sufficient evidence, these differences will be incorporated into the synthesis.

The study will use seven analytical domains to operationalize gender justice:

1. Recognition and representation
2. Meaningful participation
3. Decision-making power
4. Resource and tenure rights
5. Distribution of livelihood and material benefits
6. Conservation and care responsibilities
7. Transparency, monitoring and accountability

These domains will function as an analytical coding framework, linking the theoretical perspective to the empirical literature and policy-document analysis.

5. Methodology

Research Design

The study will use a secondary qualitative research design combining: (a) a scoping review of empirical literature, and (b) comparative qualitative documentary analysis of restoration-related policies and programmes. The scoping component will follow JBI methodological guidance and *PRISMA-ScR* reporting principles [9], [10].

A. Scoping Review

Subject to database access, searches will be conducted in Scopus, Web of Science, Sociological Abstracts and relevant environmental databases, with Google Scholar used for supplementary citation searching. Search concepts will combine:

Sundarbans + mangrove restoration/regeneration/conservation + gender/women + participation/equity/justice + governance/rights/livelihoods/agency/decision-making.

Inclusion criteria

Studies will be considered when they: concern the Bangladesh or Indian Sundarbans; are empirical studies; address gender, community governance, restoration, conservation or resource relations; provide substantive evidence relevant to at least one analytical domain.

Studies concerned exclusively with ecological processes and containing no relevant social or governance evidence will be excluded. The review will chart study characteristics, gender-related findings, participation, decision-making influence, resource access, benefits, responsibilities, social norms and institutional constraints. Publications based on the same underlying research will be checked where possible to reduce double-counting.

B. Documentary Policy Analysis

The second evidence stream will examine publicly available documents relating to mangrove restoration, regeneration or Nature-based Solutions in Bangladesh.

Documents will be selected using predefined criteria: geographical relevance; substantive restoration/regeneration component; identifiable institutional responsibility; sufficient publicly available documentary evidence. The analysis will distinguish among three levels:

Policy commitment → institutional mechanism → documented outcome

For example, a policy statement expressing support for women's participation will not automatically be treated as evidence that women possess decision-making power. Similarly, the absence of a documented mechanism will be reported as “not documented in the reviewed material”, rather than automatically interpreted as proof that the mechanism does not exist.

C. Comparative Analysis

The two evidence streams will initially be analysed separately and then compared through the seven gender-justice domains.

A policy-evidence matrix will be developed:

Analytical domain	Empirical concern	Policy commitment	Concrete mechanism	Documented outcome	Bangladesh	
Recognition						
Participation						
Decision-making						
Resource/tenure rights						
Benefit distribution						
Care/conservation responsibilities						
Accountability						

The comparison will focus on institutional responsiveness, not causal evaluation of programme effectiveness. This distinction is necessary because documentary evidence cannot independently establish implementation outcomes where no empirical evaluation is available.

6. Expected Contribution and Practical Significance

The study seeks to move discussion of gender in mangrove restoration beyond numerical participation. By connecting empirical evidence with policy and programme design, it will identify whether gender-related commitments are translated into identifiable institutional arrangements for participation, decision-making, resource access, benefit distribution and accountability.

The study may provide a practical framework for policymakers, conservation organizations and development practitioners to assess whether restoration initiatives recognize differentiated social positions, create meaningful opportunities for participation and influence, distribute benefits fairly, recognize local knowledge, and establish mechanisms for accountability.

Its principal contribution is therefore an evidence-to-policy framework for assessing gender justice in mangrove-restoration governance across the two national contexts of the *Sundarbans*.

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